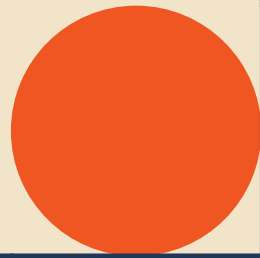


Personal Growth

 MasterClass



What's Holding You Back?

In adolescence, going through a growth spurt means getting slapped around by Mother Nature. You wake up, and a mysterious force has altered your vocal cords. Your socks no longer fit. Forget about maintaining your complexion.

The process of growing as an adult can be equally dramatic, though it demands a bit more foresight. Whether you're just starting your career or angling for a big promotion, growing with intention requires setting goals and pursuing them with confidence. This guide will provide a six-part framework to help you do just that.

First, though, you'll need to be open and receptive to change. Research shows that mindsets (assumptions and expectations you hold about yourself and the world) can have a profound effect on life outcomes, and not always in ways that you'd expect. A mindset adapted to adversity, for example—which tells you that you cannot trust others or that certain failures would be catastrophic to your sense of self—may no longer be serving you.

So before you dive in, take a moment to audit your headspace. What are you holding on to that no longer works for you? What perspectives can you jettison to make space for something new?

Ready now? Good. Let's get to work.

MICRO LESSON: THE PLIABLE MIND

One of the most influential ideas to come out of modern neuroscience is also one of the most liberating: **neuroplasticity**. This is the discovery that the brain is constantly changing—not just in terms of neuronal activity, but in regard to its architecture and connectivity. In other words, **your brain recalibrates its connections and strengthens different circuits in response to how it's being used and challenged**. The implications here are profound: **You actually have the ability to shape your brain in ways that optimize well-being, clarity, and connection. By stretching and challenging yourself with new experiences and points of view, you can form new neural connections anytime you want.**

6 Ways of Thinking About Personal Growth

Want to kick-start your development in earnest? Try using any (or all) of the following approaches as an entry point



Finding Your Passion

What inspires you?

Uncovering your passions is a lifelong process—and one that can require some detective work. According to Elaine Welteroth, you may have been conditioned to living on autopilot. “You’ve basically been set up to not know what you really love,” she says. “It takes time to cultivate that, and it takes encouragement.”

The World According to...

Elaine Welteroth

Elaine has reinvented herself professionally many times; as a writer, editor, and television host. She believes there’s power in your perspective. Never doubt that your lived experience is valuable. For more, watch her class (“Designing Your Career”) on MasterClass.

TRY THIS

As a thought experiment, ask yourself: If money wasn’t a concern, what would I be doing right now? That’s your passion. Set aside time every day to make that passion a reality, whether by stream-of-conscious journaling ideas, making to-do lists, or simply giving yourself space for additional reflection about what really fires you up.



Setting Goals

What habits do you need to develop?

There's a Goldilocks zone for ideal goal setting: You'll want to ensure that your aspirations are achievable, but you shouldn't put yourself in a position where success is guaranteed. "If it was easy, then everyone would do it," says Lewis Hamilton.

Try splitting your aspirations into short- and long-term goals and making sure to set milestones so you can track your progress along the way.

The World According to...

Lewis Hamilton

Lewis holds the all-time record for victories in Formula 1 auto racing. Like most pro drivers, he loves a good challenge; unlike most pro drivers, he doesn't come from a wealthy family. To really succeed, he suggests setting goals for yourself that feel almost impossible. For more, watch his class ("A Winning Mindset") on MasterClass.





Handling Pressure

How will you survive the squeeze?

Elite athletes thrive when the game is on the line. Do you dread those moments? Too much stress can be debilitating, but a healthy amount can fuel the fire within. “With the absence of pressure, it’s very difficult to accomplish great things,” says Geno Auriemma.

On your journey to personal growth, you’ll face pressure-packed moments that require you to keep an even head and perform. What strategies will you draw from when that time comes?

The World According to...

Geno Auriemma

Geno is one of the greatest coaches in the history of college basketball. His hard-nosed practice sessions are the stuff of legend. He believes that scenario-based preparation is the key to predicting your performance—and building habits that translate when the real pressure is on. For more, watch his class (“Leading Winning Teams”) on MasterClass.

PRESSURE POINTS

Learn how to work with healthy stressors, not against them

> Know when to ask for more time.

As anyone on deadline can attest, time pressure isn’t always great for creative tasks. Studies have found that a frenetic pace can undermine inventive thinking. It can lead to burnout and even hamper a creative team’s progress in the long run.

> **Learn your triggers.** To thrive in all areas of your life, evaluate how you cope under different levels of pressure. Do deadlines do you in? Or is it family drama? How can you minimize stressful situations by planning, practicing, and prioritizing?

> **Be real.** People who say they don’t ever get nervous are either overconfident or lying. If you’re honest and humble with those around you, your genuine vulnerability can become your superpower.



**“There’s always
pressure when
you’re trying to
accomplish some-
thing meaningful
and rewarding.”**

— GENO AURIEMMA



Learning From Failure

How will you reject defeat?

Anytime you take a risk and step outside your comfort zone, you’re exposed to the possibility of failure. But by trying to avoid failure entirely, you also preclude the possibility of growth. Try short-circuiting the fear response by embracing the possibility of abundance—of opportunities, ideas, friends, and career paths. And remember: How you respond to failure is sometimes more important than the rate at which you succeed.

“I have a great relationship with mistakes. I learn from them, I grow and I get better.”

— ISSA RAE

MICRO LESSON: RESILIENCE	
You may have heard that failure is a prerequisite for success. But is failure <i>a</i>lways helpful? One large-scale study found that not all failures lead to success. When researchers analyzed more than 775,000 grant applications submitted to the National Institutes of Health from 1985 to 2015, they found that those who succeeded and those who failed tried around the same number of times to achieve their goals. The difference between the two groups was the amount of time between consecutive failed attempts, which decreased steadily among those who eventually succeeded. In other words: Your ability to succeed comes down to how quickly you can learn from your failures.	



Never Giving Up

How will you develop a resilient mindset?

“Challenges are our greatest teachers,” according to Robin Arzón. When those challenges feel insurmountable, it’s natural to feel overwhelmed. Maybe you miss a milestone or get thrown off your routine. What are some strategies you can employ to remain resilient? When the going gets tough, how can you build yourself up rather than letting yourself languish?

The World According to...

Robin Arzón

Robin is a lawyer turned ultra-marathoner who also serves as a VP at Peloton, one of the world’s leading digital-fitness brands. She sees pain as power; for her, the natural responses to tragedy and trauma are self-repair, resilience, and tenacity. For more, watch her class (“Mental Strength”) on MasterClass.

LOSING THE PLOT

Books that offer unique perspectives on failure—and its potential benefits—in the business world and beyond

> **The Icarus Paradox** by Danny Miller looks at companies that sputtered after surging, identifying the attributes that led to their downfall.

> **The Rise** by Sarah Lewis uses poetry, playwriting, and psychology to offer nuanced insights about impatience, fulfillment, and resilience.

> **Failure** by Stuart Firestein delves into the brilliant, calamitous world of empirical research, where the inherent design of the

scientific method ensures that successes are few and far between.

> **Born Losers** by Scott A. Sandage challenges zero-sum game business mentality, begging the question: Can we lionize the victors without stripping the defeated of their humanity?



“The most likely response to tragedy, trauma, and discomfort is self-repair, resilience, and tenacity.”

— ROBIN ARZÓN



Maintaining Confidence

How can you be more confident?

Setting out into the unknown requires no small amount of confidence. “Always be your biggest hype person,” Issa Rae says. “If you’re not excited about what you’re doing, nobody else will be excited.” To build yourself up, try focusing on your internal monologue, replacing self-defeating thoughts with mantras that encourage and inspire you.

By doing this, you’ll be carrying on a long-standing human tradition. Mantras were widespread during the Vedic period, between 1,000 BCE and 50 BCE; the word ॐ,

The World According to...

Issa Rae

Issa is a television writer, actor, producer, and memoirist who parlayed her scrappy, online comedy series into Hollywood stardom. She applies a growth mindset to both success and failure. Mistakes, she says, are opportunities to learn and grow. For more, watch her class (“Creating Outside the Lines”) on MasterClass.



pronounced “om,” likely borrowed from the much older Dravidian language, was already in the lexicon. (Some spiritualists believe that it was the first sound uttered on Earth.) Saying the word creates a pleasant, vibrating sensation that can help your body relax.

Later mantras were geared toward deities; uttered in succession, they could help the speaker achieve a deeper meditative state. These days, athletes repeat mantras to get in the zone, therapists prescribe them for clients in crisis, and entrepreneurs use them during business meetings. Why not give it a shot yourself?

“The goal is for you to become a little bit more driven by what actually lights you up inside.”

— ELAINE WELTEROTH

TRY THIS

If you're open to developing a mantra of your own but aren't sure how, try using this method:

1. Spend some time alone trying stream-of-consciousness writing about what you'd like to achieve.
2. Decide which idea or goal you'd like to zero in on first.
3. Turn it into a declaration, like “I am open to receiving love,” “I am capable,” “I am in agreement with life,” or something even shorter (two words—“I am”—may do the trick.)
4. Moving forward, aim to spend five minutes each day sitting quietly or walking while repeating your mantra.

